

A Thin Veiled Night
Run the Bob Wire Home

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**EXT. SECTION LINE ROAD / CIMARRON COUNTY, OKLAHOMA - DAY
(APRIL 14, 1935)**

Blue sky, a hard bright blue, the first in a month. Bare brown fields roll out flat to every edge. A four-strand barbed wire fence on cedar posts runs straight east along the road, out of sight.

WENDELL STRAND (7), overalls, cowlick, swings an empty tin buttermilk pail in one hand and a jackrabbit's foot on a string in the other.

OPAL STRAND (12), Sunday dress with a blue sash, braids, walks beside him with her eyes on the sky like she does not trust it.

OPAL (V.O.)

The fourteenth of April, 1935. A Sunday. Nine miles north of Boise City, out at the far west end of the Oklahoma Panhandle. I was twelve. We had been eating dirt since January.

WENDELL

Mrs. Pruitt gave me three cookies.

OPAL

She gave you two. You stole the third one off the plate.

WENDELL

She didn't see.

OPAL

Jesus saw.

Wendell considers this. Puts the jackrabbit's foot in his pocket, solemn, like it might help.

EXT. STRAND FARMHOUSE / FRONT PORCH - DAY (EARLIER)

A small frame house, paint sanded off by wind. A windmill tower stands beside it, thirty feet of gray lumber. Bedsheets dry on a line, snapping white.

On the porch, WALT STRAND (40s), work shirt buttoned to the neck, sits in a kitchen chair with his hat tipped down over his face. Sunday morning. Not dressed for church.

IDA STRAND (late 30s), plain hat, Bible under her arm, hands Opal the full buttermilk pail and a pair of man's leather work gloves, cracked and old.

IDA

Gloves in your pocket.

OPAL

It's a pretty day, Mama.

IDA

Gloves in your pocket. And if a duster catches you out, you find the bob wire and you run it home. Hand over hand. Don't you let go of that wire for anything in this world.

OPAL AND WENDELL

Yes ma'am.

Opal stuffs the gloves in her coat. She looks at her father. His hat does not move.

OPAL (V.O.)

Papa strung that fence in the good years, when the wheat came up to his belt and he bought Mama a Maytag. He hadn't strung a wire since. Four years with no rain. Then the grasshoppers came and ate what the wind left, and Papa quit church.

INT. STRAND FARMHOUSE / HALLWAY - NIGHT (EARLIER, MEMORY)

Opal, in a nightgown, sits on the floor with her ear against a bedroom wall.

IDA (O.S.)

(low, through the wall)

Lord, get his feet back under him.
Don't let go of him. Please don't
let go of him.

Opal pulls her knees up and listens.

INT. LITTLE CHURCH / SUNDAY SCHOOL CORNER - DAY (EARLIER)

A plank-floored country church. Dust lines every
windowsill. Six kids on a bench.

MISS HATTIE BOWLES (60s), steel glasses, a voice that could
call hogs, holds up a flannelboard cutout of a giant with a
spear.

MISS HATTIE

Ten of those spies came back from
Canaan scared to death. Giants,
they said. Sons of Anak. And we
were like grasshoppers in our own
sight, and so we were in theirs.

The kids snicker. One BOY makes a grasshopper face.

MISS HATTIE (CONT'D)

Laugh. You've all seen what a
grasshopper is worth this year.
Two of those men stood up, though.
Caleb and Joshua. And what did
they tell the people?

Opal raises her hand.

OPAL

Don't be afraid of them. The Lord
is with us.

MISS HATTIE

Don't be afraid of them. The Lord
is with us. You put that in your
pocket, Opal Strand.

EXT. SECTION LINE ROAD - DAY (PRESENT, APRIL 14)

Opal and Wendell walk west along the fence, home direction.

A sound starts behind them, a low drumming hiss.

They turn.

BIRDS. Thousands. Sparrows, larks, blackbirds, doves, every bird in the county, coming out of the north low as the fence posts, roaring over the children's heads and on south.

Wendell ducks. Feathers drift down.

JACKRABBITS bolt down the road past their feet, dozens, running like the children are not there.

Opal rubs her bare arms. Her breath shows, faint.

OPAL (V.O.)

And the air went cold. Middle of a warm afternoon, cold enough to raise the hair on my arms.

She turns to the north.

THE BLACK ROLLER.

A wall of dirt across the whole north horizon, higher than any thunderhead, flat across the top like a mesa. Black at the bottom, brown and gold on top where the sun still catches it. The front edge turns over and over on itself like a wave coming in. Under it the prairie goes dark, a mile at a time.

No sound from it yet.

WENDELL

Opal. It's a black roller.

OPAL

Give me the pail.

She flings the pail into the ditch. Drags Wendell to the fence by the hand. Yanks the gloves out of her pocket. Left glove on Wendell. Right glove on herself.

She unties the blue sash off her Sunday dress. One end around his wrist. One end around hers. A square knot, hard, both hands, teeth.

OPAL (CONT'D)

Top wire. Glove hand. Right behind mine. You don't let go.

WENDELL

For anything in this world.

OPAL

For anything in this world.

She grips the top strand. Wendell grips it behind her.

The wall arrives.

EXT. SECTION LINE FENCE - CONTINUOUS (THE DUSTER)

WHAM. Wind first, nearly taking Opal off her feet. Then dirt. Then BLACK.

Total dark. A roar like a train in a tunnel.

Opal's bare right hand, inches from her face. The dirt swallows it.

OPAL (V.O.)

I put my hand in front of my nose and couldn't see it. Up and down went away. All I had was the roar, and dirt in my teeth, and that wire in my glove, humming with the wind.

Her gloved hand slides along the strand. Hits a barb. Lifts over it. Slides on.

Barb. Lift. Slide.

Her hand bumps a cedar post. She lets go for one breath, gropes around the post, and finds the wire again on the far side.

The sash tugs at her wrist. Wendell's glove bumps the back of hers.

OPAL (V.O.)

Papa set his posts a rod apart.
Sixteen and a half feet. A mile
and a half is four hundred and
eighty rods. I knew that from
school. I counted.

OPAL

(mouthing, under the roar)
Thirty-eight. Thirty-nine. Forty...

A tiny CRACK. A blue spark jumps off the barb in front of her fingers.

Another. Another. All down the fence, little blue sparks pop off the barbs and crawl the wire, spitting like bacon grease.

Opal's arm jerks. She grits her teeth and holds on.

OPAL (V.O.)

Dry dirt blowing makes
electricity. Papa said it could
knock a man down off a pump
handle. Knowing that didn't help
my arm.

WENDELL

(crying)
It bites!

OPAL

Hold on anyway!

A big spark. FLASH, like a camera bulb, lighting the dust.

In that flash: out in the field to the left, thirty yards off, A FIGURE stands in the blowing dirt. A man's shape.

Far too tall. Taller than a windmill tower. Long arms. A head too small for the height of it. Dirt pours around it the way creek water pours around a post. It faces the fence.

Black again.

Opal stops so short Wendell walks into her back.

WENDELL

Opal. There's men in the field.

OPAL

I know.

WENDELL

Big men.

OPAL

Keep your hand on the wire.

FLASH. Three of them now, walking toward the fence, slow and wide like men wading a creek. The wind does not touch them.

Black.

A VOICE comes, soft and close, right at Opal's ear under the roar. Kind. Fatherly.

TALL VOICE

There's a house this way, Opal.
Your papa's this way. Come off
that old wire. It's going the
wrong way. You'll smother out
there on that wire. Let go and
come.

The sash snaps tight. Opal is yanked sideways.

Wendell's glove is off the wire. He is stepping toward the voice, off into the black.

Opal's own hand skids along the strand. A barb punches through the glove into her palm. She clamps down anyway.

She plants her feet and hauls the sash with her bare arm like a calf rope. Wendell slams back against her. She jams his glove hand onto the wire and pins it there under hers.

OPAL

That ain't Papa. That ain't Papa.
Papa's at the house. Mama said.

Wendell sobs, choking on dirt.

Opal is crying too. She puts her mouth right against the wire.

INSERT - MISS HATTIE'S FLANNELBOARD (MEMORY)

The cutout giant. A cutout grasshopper beside it, tiny.

BACK TO SCENE

OPAL

(as loud as she can)
The Lord is with us! Don't be
afraid of them! The Lord is with
us! We ain't grasshoppers! We
ain't grasshoppers! Jesus, take us
home!

The wire LIGHTS.

Blue fire leaps from the barb at her hand and RUNS east along the top strand, barb to barb, faster than a horse, and stays lit. A long line of tiny blue flames, one on every barb, stretching ahead through the dust toward home. A lit path in the black.

Opal stares at it. Her glove hums. Her face stops flinching.

OPAL (V.O.)

It stopped biting.

By the blue light: the tall ones, four, five of them, pacing alongside the fence out in the field, keeping up.

One comes right up to the wire. Bends down. Its head lowers to the height of the top strand, and it stops there. A man at the edge of a cliff. It does not reach across.

TALL VOICE

Your papa's this way. You'll smother. Let go.

OPAL

The Lord is with us.

WENDELL

(hiccuping)

We ain't grasshoppers.

OPAL

Run it, Wendell. Run it!

They RUN the fence. Hand over hand. Barb, lift, slide, faster now, posts flashing by in the blue. The barbs shred the gloves. Leather strings fly off. Blood on the wire. They do not let go.

The tall ones keep pace in the dark field, talking, talking.

EXT. STRAND CORNER POST - CONTINUOUS

The fence ends at a thick cedar corner post where the section line meets the road.

The blue fire runs to the last barb on the corner post and goes out.

BLACK. The roar comes back full.

Opal clings to the corner post. Wendell clings to her.

OPAL (V.O.)

From the corner post to our porch was a hundred and ten steps across bare dirt. I'd paced it a hundred times playing Red Rover. No wire across that yard.

Silence from the tall ones. Then the voice, very close.
Coming from the yard. Between them and the house.

TALL VOICE

Stay on the wire, Opal. Stay right
there on the wire where it's safe.
Don't you come out in the open.

Opal's eyes open wide in the dirt.

OPAL (V.O.)

That was the first time one of
them told me to hold on to the
wire.

Then, under the roar, faint, hoarse, a MAN'S VOICE.
Yelling.

EXT. STRAND FARMHOUSE / FRONT PORCH - CONTINUOUS

Walt stands at the top of the porch steps in the black
wind, hat gone, bandanna over his mouth pulled down, both
hands cupped around his mouth. Behind him the screen door
bangs. A lantern on a nail swings, nearly useless, a smear
of yellow.

WALT

(bellowing)

THE LORD IS MY SHEPHERD! I SHALL
NOT WANT! HE MAKETH ME TO LIE DOWN
IN GREEN PASTURES!

Ida, behind the screen door with a wet towel over her face,
stares at him.

WALT (CONT'D)

HE LEADETH ME BESIDE THE STILL
WATERS! HE RESTORETH MY SOUL!

He gets to the end and starts again from the top. His voice
cracks. He keeps going.

EXT. STRAND CORNER POST - CONTINUOUS

Opal listens. Papa's voice comes and goes in the roar.

She takes Wendell's hand off the top strand and folds it into her own. Sash and all.

She looks at her own torn glove on the wire.

She lets go.

OPAL
The Lord is with us.

EXT. STRAND YARD - CONTINUOUS

Two small shapes walk into total black, eyes squeezed shut, hand in hand, toward the hoarse voice.

WALT (O.S.)
YEA, THOUGH I WALK THROUGH THE
VALLEY OF THE SHADOW OF DEATH...

Opal's breath fogs. Frost creeps in at the edges of her eyelashes. A shape bigger than the windmill leans down over them, a darkness inside the darkness, cold.

OPAL
(barely)
The Lord is with us.

The cold lifts. It goes up into the black the way smoke goes up a stovepipe. Gone.

They keep walking.

WALT (O.S.)
I WILL FEAR NO EVIL, FOR THOU ART
WITH ME...

Opal's boot hits the porch step.

Walt's hands come down out of the dark and catch her under the arms.

INT. STRAND FARMHOUSE / KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

The door slams. Ida stuffs a wet towel along the bottom. Wet bedsheets are nailed over every window. One lamp burns on the table; dust hangs so thick the lamp glows like a moon in fog.

Ida kneels on the floor and works the knot of the sash loose from both wrists. She turns their hands over in the lamplight. Torn palms, black with dirt, bleeding. What is left of the gloves hangs in strings.

She pulls a basin over and starts washing their hands without a word.

Walt kneels down on the floor beside her, in the dust, hat in his hands. His shoulders shake. Dust cakes in the wet on his face.

WALT

I couldn't see the fence. I
couldn't see a thing. All I could
do was holler.

IDA

(still washing)
You hollered the right thing, Walt.

Wendell, shivering in a blanket, pulls the jackrabbit's foot out of his pocket and sets it on the table, and pushes it away from him.

EXT. SECTION LINE FENCE - DAY (TUESDAY)

Sun on a world gone brown. Dirt drifted against the fence so deep only the top wire and the tips of the cedar posts show. The ground lies smooth as a bedsheet. No tracks anywhere.

Walt walks the fence line east, alone, a long way. At one post he stops, crouches, and puts his bare hand flat on the top wire.

He stays crouched there a long time.

EXT. LITTLE CHURCH - DAY (THE NEXT SUNDAY)

The Strands' truck pulls up. Walt is behind the wheel, shaved, in his one suit. He gets out and opens Ida's door.

Miss Hattie, on the church steps, sees him and takes her glasses off.

Opal, bandaged hands, climbs down out of the truck bed with Wendell.

EXT. RITA BLANCA NATIONAL GRASSLAND - DUSK (PRESENT DAY)

Buffalo grass and sand sage to every horizon, laid flat in a hard wind. A single old cedar post leans in the grass, one strand of rusted wire still hanging from it.

OPAL STRAND (90s), white hair, a cardigan, stands beside the post with a cane. Behind her a car waits on the road, headlights on.

OPAL (V.O.)

The government bought up a lot of that blown-out country after, and planted it back to grass. Wendell spent his life planting shelterbelts across three counties so the dirt would stay put. He passed in 1998. Miss Hattie lived to ninety-four.

She opens a cigar box. Inside: a pair of leather work gloves cut to strings across the palms.

She turns her own hand over. Old white scars across the palm.

OPAL (V.O.)

The one in the yard who wanted me to stay on the wire stays out of the telling. In all these years I never knew what to do with that one. The same wire that brought us

home would have kept us out there
forever, if I'd listened to the
wrong voice telling me to hold on.

The wind hums in the old wire.

She reaches out and lays her scarred palm on it. Holds it
there.

OPAL (V.O.)

I think about Papa on that porch,
hollering into a dark he couldn't
see through. And me walking toward
the sound of it with my hands open.

She takes her hand off the wire and opens it to the wind.

FADE OUT.